BUSINESS SETUP CHECKLIST

What my tax preparer told me to set up from day one. Check each one off.

- [ ] **File direct**
  Form your LLC with the Utah Division of Corporations (corporations.utah.gov). Get your EIN free at IRS.gov.

  Watch out: lookalike sites and official-looking emails charge $250–500 for the same forms, including yearly renewals.

- [ ] **Business account first**
  Every client payment lands in the business account, then you pay yourself. Never pay personal bills from it.

  Fine: paying a business expense on a personal card. Just log it.

- [ ] **Keep every receipt**
  A phone photo in a folder counts. Card statements are a weak backup in an audit.

- [ ] **Track your miles**
  Every business drive is a deduction at the IRS standard mileage rate. Log the date, where, and why.

- [ ] **Set money aside**
  25–30% of every payment if it's just you. Closer to 20% with a spouse, kids, and real expenses. Put it somewhere you won't touch.

QUESTIONS TO ASK A TAX PRO

- Should my spouse be on the LLC? (A single-member LLC pays self-employment tax on all of its profit.)
- When does an S corp make sense? (Often around $40K a year; the election is due by Dec 31.)
- Do I owe quarterly estimated taxes, and how much?

FIND YOUR FLOOR RATE

(Keep + costs) ÷ 0.7 ÷ ~1,000 hrs

Need $50K to live on? Bill about $75K. Over ~1,000 billable hours, that's about $75 an hour: the floor, not the price.

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Not tax or legal advice. Talk to a tax professional.